

Children of LESSER GODS

Hundreds of children are born in jails to women prisoners, potentially a dangerous breeding ground. They live in crowded cells with other criminals. How do they cope?

By Mitali Patel

All his growing years, Rufus Anton worked towards becoming a judge just so that he could bring to book jail officials who ill-treated him and his mother while she was serving time in prison. It may be an unusual ambition, but for a child who was born in a prison cell and spent his early years with hardened criminals and harsh prison officials, it's a valid one. Born in Trivandrum Central Jail, Anton spent the first five years with his mother, who was imprisoned for drug peddling. As he grew older, he took to lying and using abusive language. After leaving the jail premises, with the help and guidance of an NGO, Aswasa Bhavan, he is now a commerce student.

He may not have become a judge but Indian jails are a common place for such children each year. There were 1,918 children languishing in prisons across India at the end of 2007 according to the National Crime Records Bureau. Their only crime is to be born to women who have been convicted for a crime or are facing trial. Since these convicts cannot leave behind a child under the age of five, the law permits them to keep their children in jail. They stay in cramped prison cells along with prostitutes, murderers and thieves and there are no trained minders to watch over them. Sanitation, hygiene and food are hardly conducive for chil-

